

Big picture

But while players and coaches come and go, the larger question is what all this means for kabaddi's long-term future. With India bidding to host the 2030 Commonwealth Games, where kabaddi could make its debut, the sport has a chance to clean up a messy ecosystem.

Outside the Asian Games and Asian Championships, there is little international activity to keep countries beyond India and Iran engaged. Vinod Tiwari, president of the International Kabaddi Federation, explains the paradox PKL creates.

“Given that the PKL happens every year, people watch it on TV and think everything is happening and is okay with the sport. But it is not. The ecosystem has been in limbo for the last eight-odd years. If you see the other countries, apart from Iran, where players participate in large

numbers in the league, barely any other nationalities are there. A few here and there, maybe, but not too many people," he says.

At home, governance remains shaky. The Amateur Kabaddi Federation of India [AKFI] emerged from years of court-appointed oversight only to be immediately sidelined, triggering a ban that was hurriedly lifted before the women's team left for the Asian Championship in Iran.

PKL, meanwhile, positions itself as the sport's evangelist.

“Pro Kabaddi is not just a professional sport; it’s also a promotion for the actual sport. PKL made kabaddi a sport of international standard. It standardised the sport, modernised it, and helped it align with scientific processes. While the 2036 Olympics is a big target for us as a community,



NEW FORMAT OF PKL 12

- * League games reduced from 132 to 108
- * Each team plays nine home and away games
- * Drawn matches to now compulsorily have a tiebreak
- * A win earns a team two points, a loss is worth no points; grace point for a loss within a 7-point margin done away with
- * Top six teams made the playoffs previously; now teams played 7th and 8th will also join the bracket

the 2030 CWG gives us a solid chance," Rao says.

Expanding horizons

Over the years, the league has tried spreading kabaddi's gospel through talent development, broader auctions, and even an exhibition game in Melbourne featuring retired Aussie rules players. Now, PKL and Mashal Sports are working with the AKFI to revive dormant federations abroad.

"We've been looking at the West Indies — Guyana, Tobago, and others like the Virgin Islands, which had good teams. If the Commonwealth Games falls in place as a platform and we can get these teams to participate, making a case for kabaddi at the Olympic level will be the easiest thing," Rao reveals.

That global push is mirrored domestically. The league returns this year to Visakhapatnam, a venue rich in kabaddi heritage but absent since 2018.

“Vizag had been part of the league’s fabric since the inaugural season. Outside the PKL, this city also has a rich legacy in the sport. The Bharat Heavy Plate & Vessels Ltd. had a very good kabaddi team. The Port Trust also had a solid team with some international players. We’re going back to one of the foundational venues of this league. We’re confident of people turning up in large numbers, as they always have, and of sport getting a fillip consequently,” Rao adds.